



Howard County
Office of Human Trafficking Prevention
Department of Community Resources and Services
2023 ANNUAL REPORT AND PLAN FOR 2024



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2023 ANNUAL REPORT AND PLAN FOR 2024

HOWARD COUNTY OFFICE OF

HUMAN TRAFFICKING PREVENTION

Department of Community Resources and Services



BACKGROUND

In 2014, Howard County commissioned the first Howard County Human Trafficking Task Force. Task Force members concluded that there was a strong basis to recommend increased services to victims; human trafficking awareness education for everyone in our community; and additional coordination between our various partnering agencies and community-based organizations. The Department of Community Resources and Services (DCRS) created the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention (OHTP) in 2017 and the implementation of an Executive Order establishing the Howard County Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council (HTPCC). The Executive Order required the council to conduct the following activities: review and prioritize the recommendations of the Human Trafficking Task Force Report of 2014 and advise the County Executive on effective methods and organizational structure to permanently coordinate and sustain human trafficking prevention efforts in the county. The Coordination Council began meeting in mid-2017 focused on these tasks.

In early fall 2022, OHTP began a contractual partnership with TurnAround Inc. to provide direct services to survivors of human trafficking in Howard County before officially becoming the new service provider partner under a grant awarded by the U.S. Department of Justice's Office for Victims of Crime (OVC) October 1, 2022. TurnAround continued to be the official direct service partner when OHTP was awarded a grant extension from September 2023 until September 2024.

The HTPCC was made permanent by County legislation in 2019 (CB 52-2019) and remains staffed by the DCRS OHTP. In late 2019, the HTPCC and DCRS issued a multi-year report to the County Executive making several recommendations regarding the HTPCC, DCRS' OHTP and future efforts against trafficking.

BACKGROUND, CONTINUED...

Two of the most direct recommendations to OHTP were to seek outside funding sources to expand the county's ability to do this work and increase its staffing level. Both have been accomplished. In fall 2020, Howard County's collective human trafficking team of OHTP, HopeWorks of Howard County and Howard County Police Department's (HCPD) Vice and Narcotics Unit, Human Trafficking Section received a competitive three-year award from the OVC under its Enhanced Collaborative Model Task Force to Combat Human Trafficking. This award generally operationalizes local human task forces and seeks to align them with best practices in law enforcement, victim services and public engagement efforts in the anti-trafficking field. Howard County was one of only nine new jurisdictions nationwide selected for this award in 2020, joining an elite group of 45 local and statewide task forces funded by this award as of spring 2022. This award and all the team's collective progress towards its goals are managed by OHTP.

In early fall 2022, OHTP began a contractual partnership with TurnAround Inc. to provide direct services to survivors of human trafficking in Howard County before officially becoming the new service provider partner under the awarded OVC grant on October 1, 2022. TurnAround continued to be the official direct service partner when OHTP was awarded a grant extension from September 2023 until September 2024.

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COORDINATION OF HTPCC ACTIVITIES

OHTP serves as lead staff to the HTPCC which consists of over 20 appointed and volunteer members. The HTPCC is currently chaired by Dr. Jon Steuernagle, with Alicia Altamirano serving as vice-chair. It meets bi-monthly as a full group and includes an active Training, Outreach and Partnerships subcommittee that meets regularly. OHTP staff endeavor to support productive HTPCC meetings and involve HTPCC members as much as possible on appropriate work around their interests and expertise. There is a basic self-training requirement and limited confidentiality agreement for all members while meetings remain open to the public. In 2022, the HTPCC adopted updated member expectations which request all members assist in connecting OHTP to at least one community outreach opportunity per year. At different times over the past two years OHTP has facilitated smaller group meetings around policy, legislation, medical, and real estate issues that will convene only as needed going forward. OHTP continues to recruit new partners that are well-positioned to enhance our collective work to join HTPCC meetings or collaborate outside of meetings.

DRIVING THE HOWARD COUNTY CORE TEAM OF LAW ENFORCEMENT AND VICTIM SERVICES

The HTPCC Core Team meets monthly to confidentially review human trafficking investigations, cases and recent tips and discuss appropriate service provisions — always seeking to utilize a victim-centered, multi-disciplinary approach. The Core Team along with the full HTPCC also holds quarterly, generalized victim service and law enforcement data reviews — with the understanding that our data does not indicate the true prevalence of sex and/or labor trafficking in the county. Our goals are to continue regular reviews and analysis of our county law enforcement, services, training, partnerships and other task force related data, identifying any trends or key observations over time and using that information to inform future HTPCC actions, like education and outreach focused more on labor trafficking due to the low instances of labor trafficking victim identification in the county.

OHTP KEY ACTIVITIES 2022-2023

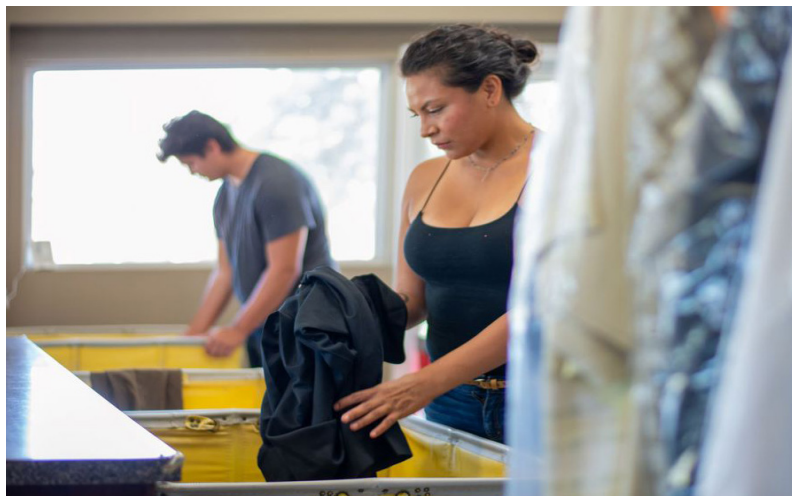
Key activities built on the office's foundation of raising community awareness of trafficking with educational presentations for community groups and workplace focused trainings. OHTP will continue to conduct these valuable activities, enhance those efforts, and take on additional projects to improve our local responses to trafficking.

1. HCPD, OHTP and TurnAround continued to conduct in-person and virtual educational presentations for local community groups with introductory education on sex and labor trafficking and available local resources. Fourteen training and educational sessions were provided to community organizations, including the Health Department; Howard County Public School students and staff; students from Howard Community College in the nursing and health-related fields; the Maryland Department of Transportation; and the legal staff from Luminus who provide immigration services. During this reporting period, these sessions reached approximately 354 individuals.
2. The OHTP and different HTPCC members continue to conduct passive outreach through community-wide events and initiatives to the general public to raise awareness and share appropriate local contact information for TurnAround, HCPD and the National Human Trafficking Hotline.

KEY ACTIVITIES, CONTINUED...

3. The OHTP and contracted partner Centro de los Derechos del Migrante (CDM) conducted its final outreach visits (funded by Howard County), to known H2A (*temporary U.S. agricultural work*) and some H2B (*temporary U.S. non-agricultural work*) workers in June 2023 to continue making positive rights-based contact with this group of highly vulnerable migrant workers.
 - Visits were made to retail locations workers tend to frequent after work. Forty-eight individuals were spoken with in Spanish and provided information about their rights at work and CDM's services.
 - One person asked what discrimination can look like at work, and another said that she might call to speak to CDM's legal team because she had an experience on the job and wants to know if her employer violated the law.
 - Repeat visits were also conducted to residences of agricultural workers in the western part of the county. On the initial visits, workers expressed the need for food to make ends meet. CDM workers brought several bags of perishable/non-perishable foods. Workers confirmed that, because of the amount of rain in the last few weeks, they haven't had as much work, and were grateful for the assistance.
 - One man said he and his colleagues have really been wanting to take English classes but haven't found one that fits with their work schedule. CDM summer interns were able to identify options and follow up with him.
 - Another expressed concerns about taxes and what can be deducted from his paycheck. A recent Facebook Live hosted by CDM about taxes for H-2A workers was shared with him.

Altogether, we reached 51 people on this trip.



KEY ACTIVITIES, CONTINUED...

4. The Core Team confidential meetings moved to quarterly case review for adult sex trafficking cases and credible tips as well as any labor trafficking cases and tips. A separate multidisciplinary team case review meeting for sex trafficking cases involving youth under the age of 24 years old was established by TurnAround's state-funded youth sex trafficking regional navigator in December when it held its first meeting. Participants in that meeting are TurnAround's Regional Navigator, HCPD, our local Department of Social Services, Howard County Public School principals or key staff to the extent appropriate on a particular case. Confidentiality and information sharing protocols are in place to protect all personal information of victims in each meeting. Meetings to date have focused on:
 - How referrals and occasional in-person support on law enforcement operations from TurnAround will occur.
 - How credible referrals from OHTP and other key partners — particularly with victims 24 years old and under — should be sent to TurnAround staff.
 - How to confirm service availability, provision, ideal methods of communication outside of meetings and protocol development.
5. OHTP online training was launched and is now required to be taken by all Howard County employees. The training was virtually completed by approximately 3,000 full-time and contingent employees as of September 2023.
6. The Community Assessment was completed and compiled into a quantitative and qualitative report. Work will begin on analyzing the findings of the assessment to recognize the vulnerabilities of human trafficking victims and ways to best provide outreach and support.



Howard County Human Trafficking Key Data Highlights*

DIRECT SERVICE PROVIDER DATA

15

January 1 through December 31, 2022.

The number of trafficking survivors TurnAround served and provided a wide variety of supportive and high-quality services.

35

January 1 through December 31, 2023.

The number of trafficking survivors TurnAround served and provided a wide variety of supportive and high-quality services.

HOWARD COUNTY LAW ENFORCEMENT DATA

24

January 1 through December 31, 2022.

The number of potential trafficking victims HCPD's human trafficking section identified and offered to connect them with appropriate, high-quality services.

39

January 1, 2023, through December 31, 2023.

The number of potential trafficking victims HCPD's human trafficking section identified and offered to connect them with appropriate, high-quality services.

HUMAN TRAFFICKING VICTIM DATA HCPD VICE AND NARCOTICS DIVISION

Data represents the number of unduplicated contacts with potential victims by HCPD's highly-trained unit in human trafficking.

2018 — 10 adults + two juveniles = **12** TOTAL VICTIMS

2019 — 29 adults + three juveniles = **32** TOTAL VICTIMS

2020 — 15 adults + two juveniles = **17** TOTAL VICTIMS

2021 — seven adults + one juveniles = **8** TOTAL VICTIMS

2022 — 23 adults + two juveniles = **25** TOTAL VICTIMS

2023 — 36 adults + three juveniles = **39** TOTAL VICTIMS

* Caution: These numbers are NOT indicators of prevalence of sex or labor trafficking and can be misleading taken out of appropriate context.

HOWARD COUNTY VICTIM SERVICES DATA

During the 12-month period January 1 through December 31, 2023, TurnAround served 50 victims of trafficking, providing the following services:

- Case management.
- Protection and safety planning.
- Therapy services (traditional, cultural, alternative healing, art, writing, or play therapy).
- Transitional housing.
- Transportation assistance.

NOTE: TurnAround offers a broad spectrum of direct services and referrals. The aforementioned list represents the most highly utilized resources for survivors during the designated time period.

Our data is consistent with law enforcement and service trends in many jurisdictions nationwide: heavily focused on sex trafficking, not labor trafficking, or cases involving sex and labor trafficking. The length of time an individual trafficking victim remains actively in services with a high-quality service provider can vary significantly.

While future data sets will unlikely paint a complete picture of trafficking in the county, we expect they will allow us to draw better conclusions in terms of focus and future resource allocation.

OHTP urges readers not to draw any conclusions about the prevalence of trafficking in Howard County from any of the law enforcement, victim services or OHTP data presented above. Law enforcement and service data can be misleading without appropriate context. It remains OHTP's hope that, in the next several years, with more focused outreach efforts and the building out of the county's regional navigator presence, Howard County will see more sex and labor trafficking cases identified, investigated and prosecuted with victim-centered methods, and victims of all ages will be provided the high-quality services that best fit their needs.

Over the next year the county will benefit from a longer, steadier stream of relevant local law enforcement and victim service data alongside TurnAround for trafficking victims of all ages. While future data sets will unlikely paint a complete picture of trafficking in the county, we expect it will allow us to draw better conclusions in terms of focus and future resource allocation.

OHTP WORK PLAN FOR 2024

STRENGTHEN OUR CORE TEAM AND THE HTPCC BY

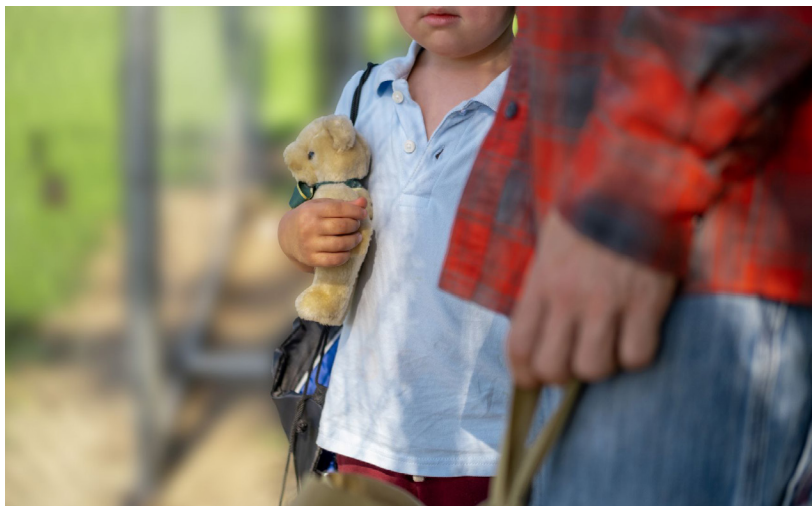
1. Enhancing and sustaining critical direct services available to trafficking survivors, embracing a stronger, regional approach with local direct service providers.
2. Leaning on support from HTPCC members, completing and adopting protocols that establish lasting best-practice guidelines for the HTPCC.
3. Initiating positive, ongoing survivor leader and lived experience expert consulting relationships to enhance all our work.
4. Conducting additional community awareness and education initiatives and trainings using standardized materials in partnership with the HTPCC.
 - a. Continuing to enhance the OHTP website with useful learning opportunities for the public, including industry fact sheets, noting applicable labor laws in industries where exploitation occurs nationally.
 - b. Maintaining a community outreach annual calendar with HTPCC member's support.
 - c. Growing our list of community contacts and partner DCRS offices.
5. Remaining data-driven in our work with detailed quarterly data reviews and ongoing vulnerability reassessments. These will guide law enforcement, service provision, outreach and partnership strategy, and resource direction.

LAY FOUNDATION FOR GREATER VICTIM IDENTIFICATION, ESPECIALLY LABOR TRAFFICKING

1. Conduct and complete a thorough analysis of the Community Assessment findings that highlight the many vulnerabilities of human trafficking victims. Through this analysis, strategic approaches for outreach and training will be able to be developed and implemented.
2. Build connections and partnerships with organizations focused on addressing labor rights, immigration services, labor exploitation, and labor trafficking.
3. Continue to implement basic human trafficking awareness training for all Howard County employees, reaching approximately 3,000 individuals.

IMPLEMENT LONG-TERM, MULTI-MODAL, PROACTIVE OUTREACH PLAN

1. Continued expansion of the reach of OHTP through its HTPCC, and new partnerships with other county agencies, immigrant-focused groups and service organizations, key faith and community organizers and groups, businesses, and business organizations.
2. Increased collaboration with various county commissions to ensure relevant needs of residents and populations are included in outreach work.
3. Consistent resident-led outreach efforts to vulnerable workers. Focus will be on embracing the best practice of meeting workers safely where they are, building trust and offering useful information on their rights and other immediate needs. We will embrace a rights-based approach to this outreach, meaning that workers are not passive recipients of services, but active participants in the direction of their lives.
4. Marketing plans for print and digital materials, with thoughtful pacing of future material rollouts and public awareness campaigns, social media, branding and consistency for OHTP and HTPCC.
5. Prioritizing future areas of focus for training and community awareness efforts including
 - a. Strategic informational postings in businesses, churches and other religious and community congregation locations, and other public locations in the county.
 - b. Public recognition for voluntary staff training(s) using live or online recorded content created by and/or approved by the HTPCC and other initiatives.
 - c. Updates to county contracting policies to emphasize human trafficking awareness and zero tolerance for labor violations.



OUTREACH PLAN, CONTINUED...

6. Strategizing and planning events for Human Trafficking Prevention Month for community members, lived experience experts, partners, and direct service providers.
 - a. OHTP and HTPCC started the groundwork for these events which took place on January 17 and 31, 2024.
 - b. OHTP, along with TurnAround, participated in a virtual film discussion highlighting the realities of sex trafficking in the United States. This discussion was filmed and recorded and placed on the OHTP's website for access and distribution.
 - c. OHTP and the HTPCC hosted an expert panel event within the community January 31, 2024, which consisted of expert partners in the field and focused on the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services theme of Partner2Prevent and highlighted prevention efforts and the importance of community collaboration. Several community partners and service providers were present to network with approximately 50 registered participants.
7. Planning and facilitating community events that highlight the needs of those with lived experience while remaining trauma informed. These events will focus on community partnerships and action steps for the residents of Howard County to become involved with the work of OHTP in a meaningful way that addresses direct prevention efforts in 2024.



OHTP PLANS FOR 2024 AND BEYOND

In addition to continuing its core work of ensuring survivors are offered high quality services; supporting survivors and law enforcement each appropriately; overseeing our data efforts and OVC award activities; and coordinating community education, awareness and training efforts, OHTP plans to:

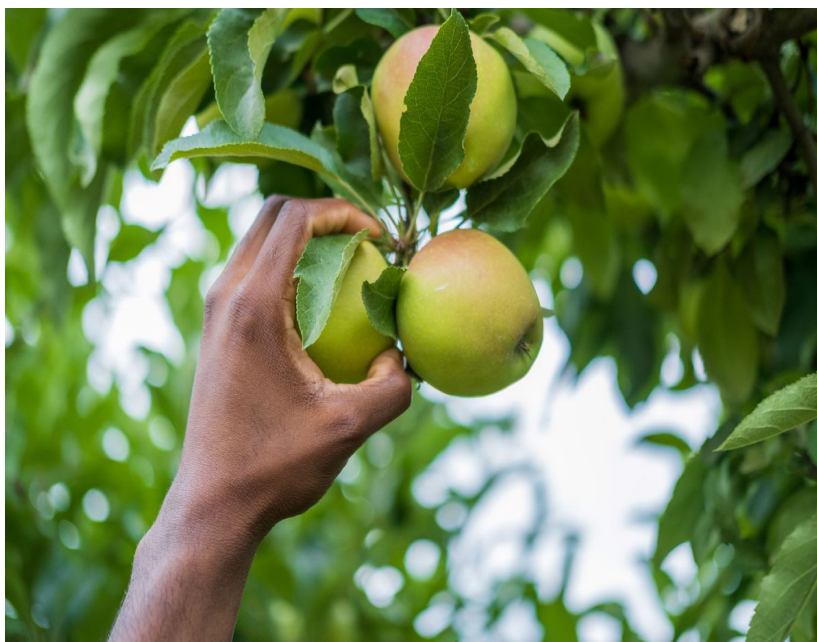
1. Complete and continue to work on OVC Purpose Area 2 award activities, consider future applications for OVC and other sources of outside funds to sustain effective anti-trafficking work.
2. Utilize OVC funds for needed contractual partnerships when serving victims of labor trafficking and engaging with lived experience experts.
3. Begin steps to create a survivor alliance coalition with Howard County for lived experience experts.
4. Implement sustainable outreach plans while continuously revisiting new data and vulnerability indicators.
5. Attend human trafficking specific conferences, summits and conventions for professional development and to remain updated on best practice measures.
6. Develop and standardize trainings for the community and facilitate specialized trainings for community partners who work directly with residents who may be more vulnerable to human trafficking.
7. In partnership with TurnAround, and other local and regional partners, work to increase emergency shelter and longer-term housing options and work opportunities for trafficking survivors. Business recognition initiatives, other existing partnerships will hopefully play a positive role in these activities.



OUR MISSION

Our mandate to work against sex and labor trafficking in Howard County is supported in part through the work of the HTPCC, an appointed and voluntary body which held its first meeting in December 2017. The HTPCC was made permanent by County legislation, (CB 52-2019) that took effect January 2020.

OHTP aligns with the values and standards of the Maryland Human Trafficking Task Force, partnering with anti-trafficking agencies and organizations which conform responsibly to best practices in the field.



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